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General requirements	NPOP-specific	EU-specific	COR-specific
Black text = applies across schemes	Colour-coded text = NPOP-specific	Colour-coded text = EU-specific	Colour-coded text = COR-specific

1. Purpose

To establish and maintain a uniform, impartial, controlled and scheme-compliant process for application review, inspection planning, certification review, certification decision, certificate issuance, renewal, surveillance, complaints, appeals and related certification controls for all operators seeking certification from GO4AGRI within the approved scope of the company.

2. Scope

This procedure applies to certification activities under NPOP, EU Regulation (EU) 2018/848 and the Canadian Organic Regime (COR), and covers annual, additional, unannounced, surveillance and change-related evaluations, review, certification decision and issuance of certification documentation.

It applies to all interested clients including farmers, grower groups, processors, traders, apiculturists, wild harvesters, animal husbandry operators and input manufacturers, subject to GO4AGRI's approved certification scope.

3. Responsibility

- The CEO has overall responsibility for implementation of this procedure.
- Certification Manager is responsible for allocation of reviewers/certification officers and for ensuring that review and decision activities are performed in a timely and compliant manner.
- Managers, evaluators, reviewers, certifiers and the accounts department are responsible for compliance with the relevant parts of this procedure.

4. Key references and linked procedures

- PRO04_Client Registration procedure
- PRO10_Inspection and Additional Controls
- PRO12_Non-Conformance Handling procedure
- PRO18_Catalogue of Measures (EU) Sanction Catalogue Procedure
- PRO05_Suspension, Cancellation, Withdrawal and Appeal Procedure
- PRO22_Exchange of Information
- PRO26_Verification of Input Compliance
- PRO27_Grower Group Operating Procedure
- PRO30_Procedure for Control of Certificates

5. Initial contact and request for certification

Interested clients may contact GO4AGRI through any suitable means to request an application package. At a minimum, the request should include:

- Name and address of the interested party
- Scope/categories requested
- Crops/products grown, made, processed, traded or manufactured
- Total farm area in hectares and/or operational capacity, as applicable
- Exact location of operations
- Number and area of members in case of grower group certification
- Previous certification status, including any denial or withdrawal

6. Application package and quotation

GO4AGRI sends the application package and quotation for certification services. The application package consists of, as applicable:

- Copy/link of applicable standard
- FMO60_Commercial Unavailability
- FMO61_Notice of Change/Addition Request Form
- FMO64_Material_Input Review Request Form
- FMO06_Application
- FMO10_Non_GMOs_Declaration
- FMO052_Recording Supplier Certificate Checks
- FMO54_Equipment List
- FMO55_Input List
- FMO56_Non-Organic Planting Stock
- FMO57_Production Yield & Inventory List
- FMO43_USCOEA – Declaration
- FMO58_Field History
- FMO059_Product_Reconciliation_GG
- FMO06-Annex A_Approved farmer List
- FMO06-Annex B_Removed farmer List
- FMO08A_OMP Production
- FMO063_Master_Ingredient_Supplier_List
- FMO06 Annex D_MIPS
- FMO06_Application
- FMO06-Annex C_List of Product
- FMO08B_OMP Processing & Handling (Food & Feed)
- FMO42_Nonorganic Ingredient Declaration
- FMO051_Organic Flavouring and Non-GM Declaration
- FMO08C_OMP_Wild_Collection
- PRO03_Certification Procedure

Where the quotation has already been shared based on initial information, a copy of the certification agreement is provided to the client. If quotation has not yet been issued, the application is first reviewed for suitability, after which an offer/quotation is prepared. Once the offer is accepted, the certification agreement is executed and registration proceeds.

7. Submission of application and fees

The duly completed and signed application form, associated forms and supporting documents shall reach GO4AGRI by post, courier, hand delivery or email. For email applications, signatures may be collected at the time of inspection; scanned signed pages are acceptable.

Advance payment for inspection and certification is acceptable by demand draft, cheque (subject to realization), NEFT/RTGS/IMPS/wire transfer or other approved online payment methods, with proper receipt.

8. Capacity review and acceptance of application

GO4AGRI reviews the application to verify its capacity to carry out certification for the requested scope. This includes checking accreditation/approval availability for the requested certification scope. Based on this review, the request may be declined or may proceed to the next stage.

An authorized evaluator/initial reviewer performs this capacity review and coordinates as necessary with the marketing team.

[EU-specific] Example: if an operator applies for Livestock (Category B) under EU 2018/848, GO4AGRI shall not proceed where such scope is not within its approved capacity. The currently referenced EU scope in the base document is limited to Category D and Category E.

9. Registration process

After receipt of the completed application package, certification agreement and advance payment, and after confirming that GO4AGRI has capacity to certify the project, the client is registered in accordance with PRO-04 Client Registration Procedure and is issued a registration number and FMO-11 Letter of Registration. Registration proceeds only after successful review.

Inspection shall not be carried out before completion of the registration process, except where an exception applies such as certification body transfer.

10. Application review and certification planning

The application package, including the organic plan / organic system plan and all associated documents, is reviewed before inspection planning. The review may be assigned to an inspector/auditor competent for that scope.

Man-days for inspection shall be calculated based on factors including, but not limited to, number of sites, subcontracted operations, length of time in organic/in-conversion status, complexity of the system, complexity of products and number of products.

The client is expected to possess and fulfill the requirements of the applicable standards/regulations. GO4AGRI communicates relevant updates in normative documents to clients through letters/emails.

11. Scheduling of inspection

In consultation with the operator and considering scheme requirements, GO4AGRI fixes inspection/audit dates. GO4AGRI reserves the right for observers, witnessing auditors, accreditation body personnel or other relevant authorities to accompany the assigned inspector/auditor, where applicable.

The producer/operator shall maintain evidence demonstrating compliance with applicable requirements. Non-availability of evidence may result in certification not being possible until the required evidence is provided.

[General group certification control] In the case of producer groups, the reviewer shall verify that the QMS audit is performed first and that the correct sample size is externally inspected.

12. Inspection execution and report content

GO4AGRI conducts inspection and records all non-conformities/non-compliances in the inspection report. A signed copy of the report is provided to the client. Closure of non-conformities may be demonstrated by documents, records, photographs or, where required, by a further chargeable follow-up visit.

The reviewer/certification officer shall verify that:

- All sites relevant to the operation, including subcontracted activities, have been evaluated by the inspector
- The audit pack is complete in all respects, with completed checklists, sufficient comments/justification and evaluation of all control points
- Parallel production, parallel ownership, harvesting, declarations and commitments made in the application and contract have been properly reviewed and recorded where applicable
- Sufficient objective evidence is recorded for traceability of the evaluation process, such as samples selected, evidence reviewed and personnel interviewed
- Corrective actions and supporting proof are sufficient to close the non-conformities raised during inspection

[COR-specific] On-site inspection shall be scheduled as applicable to the nature of the product and, for processing operations, at the time of processing activities. The assigned verification officer/inspector shall not inspect the same

operation for more than 3 consecutive years. **{GO4AGRI procedure: Auditor/inspector shall not inspect the same operation for more than 2 consecutive years }**

[COR-specific] The detailed COR inspection report shall include: date, time and duration of inspection; names of interviewees; identification of land/premises visited; types of documentation audits performed; inspection results; and list of findings identified.

13. Invoicing

After inspection, GO4AGRI issues the final invoice. The operator shall pay the balance of the final invoice within 30 days after inspection.

The certification file is forwarded for review and decision only after settlement of all outstanding dues where required under the contract and procedure.

14. Certification review

Review and certification shall be carried out in a timely manner in accordance with the schedule agreed in the contract. As stated in FMO-07, the certificate is to be issued within 30 days once the requirements for certification are fulfilled, i.e. evaluation completed, detected non-conformities closed as applicable, and certification fees paid.

The Certification Manager allocates reviewer/certification officers for review and certification.

The Certification Manager must ensure that all non-conformances, including minor, major and critical non-compliances, are appropriately dealt with before certification review and decision.

Any critical non-conformity, and in some cases major non-conformity as per the relevant sanction catalogue/catalogue of measures, or any contractual or technical non-conformance with potential impact on certified status, shall lead to immediate suspension/withdrawal or shall prevent grant of certification as applicable.

Any issue with potential impact on certified status shall be informed to APEDA or the concerned accreditation/regulatory body or authority, such as CFIA, IOAS or the EU Commission, in accordance with PRO-22 (Exchange of Information).

15. Scheme-specific decision rules for open non-conformities

[NPOP-specific] Certification cannot be granted with an open major non-conformity.

[NPOP-specific] Certification may be granted with an open minor non-conformity only where organic integrity of the process or product is not affected. Such open minor non-conformity must be closed before the next renewal inspection, and a corrective action plan must be submitted within the timeline provided.

[EU-specific] Certification cannot be granted with open non-conformities (minor, major or critical). An OFI may be verified at the next annual inspection.

[COR-specific] Certification cannot be granted with open non-conformities (minor, major or critical). An OFI may be verified at the next annual inspection.

16. Certification decision

Where review of the checklist, inspection report and associated corrective action demonstrates compliance with the applicable organic standard and normative documents, certification may be granted and the review/decision shall be recorded in the Certification Decision Report FMO23a_Certification Decision Report (CDR) as applicable.

The certification decision is communicated to the Certification Manager, who ensures required system entry and certificate issuance. For NPOP, the certification decision is uploaded to TraceNet; where electronic entry is not applicable, a paper certificate is prepared as per the relevant approved template.

If there is confusion or complexity related to certification, a certification committee may be formed consisting of competent certifiers and the Quality Manager to discuss and arrive at a decision.

Where review shows that the operation is not in compliance with the requirements of the applicable standard and normative documents, certification cannot be granted and the decision shall be recorded in FMO23_Compliance Letter/FMO24_Negative Decision Letter and the client shall be informed. In the case of an already certified client, suspension shall be initiated as applicable.

[COR-specific] If an operator makes a false statement regarding its production system or does not respond to outstanding non-compliances, GO4AGRI shall issue a written notice of denial of certification.

17. Certification validity and certification documents

The date of certification issuance is the date of certification decision.

[COR-specific] The certification of a product, once issued, remains valid unless suspended or cancelled by GO4AGRI according to the requirements of the SFCR and is subject to annual renewal/continuation controls.

[COR-specific] For COR packaging and labeling certificates and attestation of compliance, the document expires at the end of 12 months or when cancelled by GO4AGRI, as applicable.

[EU-specific] EU certificates are valid for 1 year from the date of issuance and remain subject to maintenance of certification requirements.

Recommendations for certification decision based on review are documented within the Certification Decision Report unless review and certification decision are completed concurrently by the same person, where allowed under the established system.

18. Closure timelines, sanctions and verification of corrective action

The operator shall fulfill conditions and settle non-conformities within one month in case of already certified clients and within three months in case of new applicants, or within the timeline imposed by the relevant sanctions' procedure.

All non-conformities against the ICS in group certification must be closed within the allotted time. The base requirement states 100% compliance of all applicable clauses of the operation with no major non-conformity and no critical non-conformity. Preventive action plan submission may be accepted to support grant of scope certificate only where consistent with the applicable scheme rules and product integrity is not affected.

If non-conformities are not closed within the stipulated timeline, or within a shorter time based on severity, appropriate sanctions according to FMO-09 / the relevant sanction catalogue shall be initiated. For already certified clients, this may lead to suspension; for new applicants, the certification process will not proceed until requirements are met.

GO4AGRI verifies actions taken on non-conformities, which may include a surveillance/follow-up visit. If a surveillance visit is required, it is scheduled in consultation with the client and charged accordingly.

[COR-specific] GO4AGRI informs the operator of identified non-compliances and corrective action requirements within 30 working days of receipt of the audit report. The operator must address each non-compliance or submit a plan of action with a completion date not exceeding 90 working days. GO4AGRI verifies corrective action for all non-conformities by on-site visit or other appropriate forms of verification.

19. Issuance of certificates and amendment control

GO4AGRI issues the certificate not later than one month after completion of all necessary inspections, closure of non-conformities as required, and settlement of dues amounting to 100% of the final contract value.

[NPOP-specific] NPOP certificates are issued according to NPOP rules and are generated from TraceNet.

[EU-specific] EU 2018/848 Organic Scope Certificate / Official Organic Certificate may be issued through TRACES NT in accordance with EU requirements and EU 2021/1698 as referenced in the base documents.

[COR-specific] COR certificate / attestation / packaging and labeling certification documents shall be issued as per the approved COR family of certification documents and applicable operating manual requirements.

The certificate is not transferable. On change of ownership, an initial inspection is needed and continuation of organic status is decided in accordance with the competent authority/accreditation requirements. In case of sanction, suspension or withdrawal, information shall be given to affected parties and, where applicable, to the other certification body if the client operates with another CB. Information to APEDA shall be communicated within 30 days where required.

For COR or EU, the same client cannot be certified with two certification bodies at the same time.

Certificates may be issued by post or hand delivery and proof of delivery shall be retained. Any difference noticed by the client must be brought to the notice of GO4AGRI within 7 days of certificate generation.

[NPOP-specific] Where the difference is due to CB error, an amended certificate is issued within 14 days without charge. Where the difference results from incorrect client data, the amended certificate is issued within 28 days and may be charged as per the Schedule of Fees. TraceNet changes may require additional time and, where necessary, APEDA permission.

If non-conformities cannot be closed due to reasons beyond the client's control, a letter of non-compliance may be issued only on written requests by the client. Such a letter does not replace or avoid sanctioning.

Other than the above non-compliance letter, GO4AGRI shall not issue any communication other than the certificate to or about a producer to demonstrate organic status, unless it refers to sanctions.

20. Use of logos, claims and marks

India Organic Logo, GO4AGRI logo, COR logo, EU logo and any claim of organic certification by GO4AGRI shall not be used unless the client has been granted the relevant license/authorization and valid certification under the applicable scheme.

[NPOP-specific] Use of India Organic Trademark and Logo shall be governed by NPOP Chapter 6.

[EU-specific] Use of the EU logo shall comply with EU Regulation (EU) 2018/848 and applicable delegated/implementing acts.

[COR-specific] Use of the COR logo shall comply with applicable COR regulations and conditions of use.

21. Maintenance of certification, annual follow-up and renewal

Surveillance inspection shall be conducted by GO4AGRI in accordance with scheme requirements and PRO-10.

Annual follow-up inspections are mandatory. GO4AGRI will normally follow up with the client for renewal and, on request, send the application form approximately 3 months before certificate expiry. However, responsibility for timely submission of renewal applications before certificate expiry remains with the client.

The follow-up/subsequent inspection should be carried out while standing crop/active operations are present and should be avoided in the off-season when no activities are going on.

Each year, before renewal inspections, the client shall notify GO4AGRI of its production schedule for crop products.

Other than normal announced inspections, GO4AGRI shall carry out additional and unannounced inspections on a risk basis.

[NPOP-specific] Unannounced inspection of PI and additional 10% of certified clients will be conducted by GO4AGRI, as stated in the base procedure and subject to PRO-10.

[NPOP-specific] For NPOP, GO4AGRI will inform the certificate holder in advance of the intended unannounced visit, normally not exceeding 24 hours. If the first proposed date cannot be accepted for medical or other justifiable reasons, the certificate holder gets one more chance; a written warning is issued if the first proposed date is not accepted. Another 24-hour notification is given. If the visit cannot take place due to non-justifiable reasons, suspension of all products is issued.

[EU-specific] For EU, no prior information is given regarding unannounced inspections. Please refer to PRO10 - **Inspection and Additional Controls** for detailed process.

[COR-specific] In addition to annual inspections, GO4AGRI plans and conducts unannounced inspections representing 5% of certified clients under COR, subject to any exceptions stated in C.2.6 Table 7 of the operating manual.

[COR-specific] COR unannounced inspections are selected annually on a random and/or risk basis and may also result from complaints or investigations. Such inspections may be limited in scope and cover only certain aspects of the operation.

[COR-specific] Risk-based criteria for unannounced inspection selection include: type of operator; new or experienced operator; size and complexity of operation; type and value of product; number of parcels/animal units under transition; local geography; only organic, split operation or parallel production; total quantity produced/processed; rapid increase versus stable production levels; compliance history; and complaints received.

22. COR-specific continuation of certification requirements

[COR-specific] A certified operator shall submit required information annually, beginning on the day the certificate is issued and no later than the day that is 6 months before the end of that period. After verification of the information, GO4AGRI proceeds with on-site inspection to check continued compliance.

[COR-specific] During continuation inspection, the inspector verifies implementation of any changes in organic standards, GO4AGRI requirements, previously submitted corrective actions and continued fulfillment of requirements for certification. GO4AGRI then makes its certification decision for continued certification.

23. Changes affecting certification

When the certification scheme introduces new or revised requirements affecting the client, GO4AGRI shall communicate these changes to all affected clients.

GO4AGRI shall also consider other changes affecting certification, including changes initiated by the client, verify their implementation and take actions required by the scheme. Depending on the case, actions may include evaluation, review, decision, issuance of revised certification documentation to extend/reduce scope, and revision of surveillance activities.

24. Complaints and appeals

If the client is not satisfied with any operation associated with inspection or certification carried out by GO4AGRI, a complaint may be made to GO4AGRI. If any decision taken by GO4AGRI is not agreeable to the client, the client may appeal against that decision.

Complaint and appeal procedures are available on request and are handled under the relevant GO4AGRI procedures.

[COR-specific] Complaints and appeals may be related to any part or process of GO4AGRI. Refer to PRO-19 Procedure for suspension, cancellation, withdrawal and appeal - COR and EU, and PRO-06 Complaint (and investigation) Procedure.

25. Records and retention

GO4AGRI maintains certification records and decision records in accordance with applicable scheme and internal document control requirements.

[COR-specific] GO4AGRI shall maintain records of its COR certification activities for 5 years.

[COR-specific] GO4AGRI shall maintain records of major changes affecting the organization during the previous year, including changes in corporate structure, directors, administrative structure, key managers and committee members.

[COR-specific] Records maintained include, but are not limited to: certificates newly issued, renewed and withdrawn by operator category; number of annual inspections; number of unannounced inspections; number of non-conformities issued; number of samples collected; number of complaints; and number of attestations of compliance issued.

26. Availability of standards and precedence of normative documents

[NPOP-specific] Updated NPOP documents are available through APEDA.

[COR-specific] COR Operation Manual and SFCR requirements are available online.

[EU-specific] EU Organic Regulations are available online.

Where any conflict exists between this procedure and the applicable normative/reference documents, the relevant normative documents and the valid version at the time of certification shall prevail.

Further details regarding NPOP, EU 2018/848 and its delegated/implementing acts, COR and other applicable schemes are available on request.